

A CLOSER LOOK

The power of touch

When a baby cries, our instinct is to pick him up and cuddle with him. However, taking care of a special-care baby can make soothing touch a little more complicated. When your baby goes into the neonatal intensive care unit (NICU), he may be in an incubator or in a special crib and attached to machines and IVs that mean you can't always pick him up when you want to. However, simply touching your baby can be hugely beneficial for him.

Contact with your baby Studies show that caressing your baby through the holes in the sides of the neonatal crib, and, once he is strong enough to be picked up, holding him whenever you can and nestling him against your bare skin as much as possible, can help with bonding and trigger the release of hormones that aid milk production.

Less stressed Being close to you and hearing your familiar voice help to reduce the amount of the stress hormone cortisol in your baby's body. Babies getting special care are more tolerant of medical care, becoming less distressed during examinations, general procedures, and administration of medication, if they've felt the power of your touch.